Sew a Button

A pocket card for the ten minutes it takes to save a favorite shirt — one side to thread and stitch, the other only if you want to frame it.

What you need:

- A button that matches (or a spare from the shirt's spare-button pouch)
- A needle with thread about 24 inches long (roughly the length of your arm)
- Sharp scissors

Putting the thread on the needle

1. Cut about 24 inches of thread. Shorter means you'll run out mid-way; much longer means tangles.
2. Lick the tip of the thread to stiffen it, then slide it through the eye of the needle.
3. Pull the thread until the two ends meet, and tie them together in a knot. A doubled thread is strong and fastens faster.

Attaching the button

1. Hold the two sides of the garment closed, the way it looks when worn. Mark where the button should sit by eye.
2. Push the needle up from the wrong side of the fabric so the knot ends up hidden on the inside.
3. Stitch down through one pair of button holes, then up through the other pair. Repeat 3 or 4 times.
4. For a shirt button, lay a toothpick on top of the button while you stitch the last couple of rounds — it leaves a tiny stem so the button doesn't pull too tight.
5. Remove the toothpick. Wrap the loose thread 3 times around the stitches underneath the button, then poke the needle through to the back.
6. Tie a small knot by catching a single thread of the fabric with the needle, then pull the thread through it.
7. Trim the ends close to the fabric. Done — work the button through its buttonhole a few times to feel how it sits.

Kind tips: If the thread knots up, don't fight it — cut it, retie, start again from the last good stitch. Everyone's first button is slightly crooked. Crooked buttons still work.